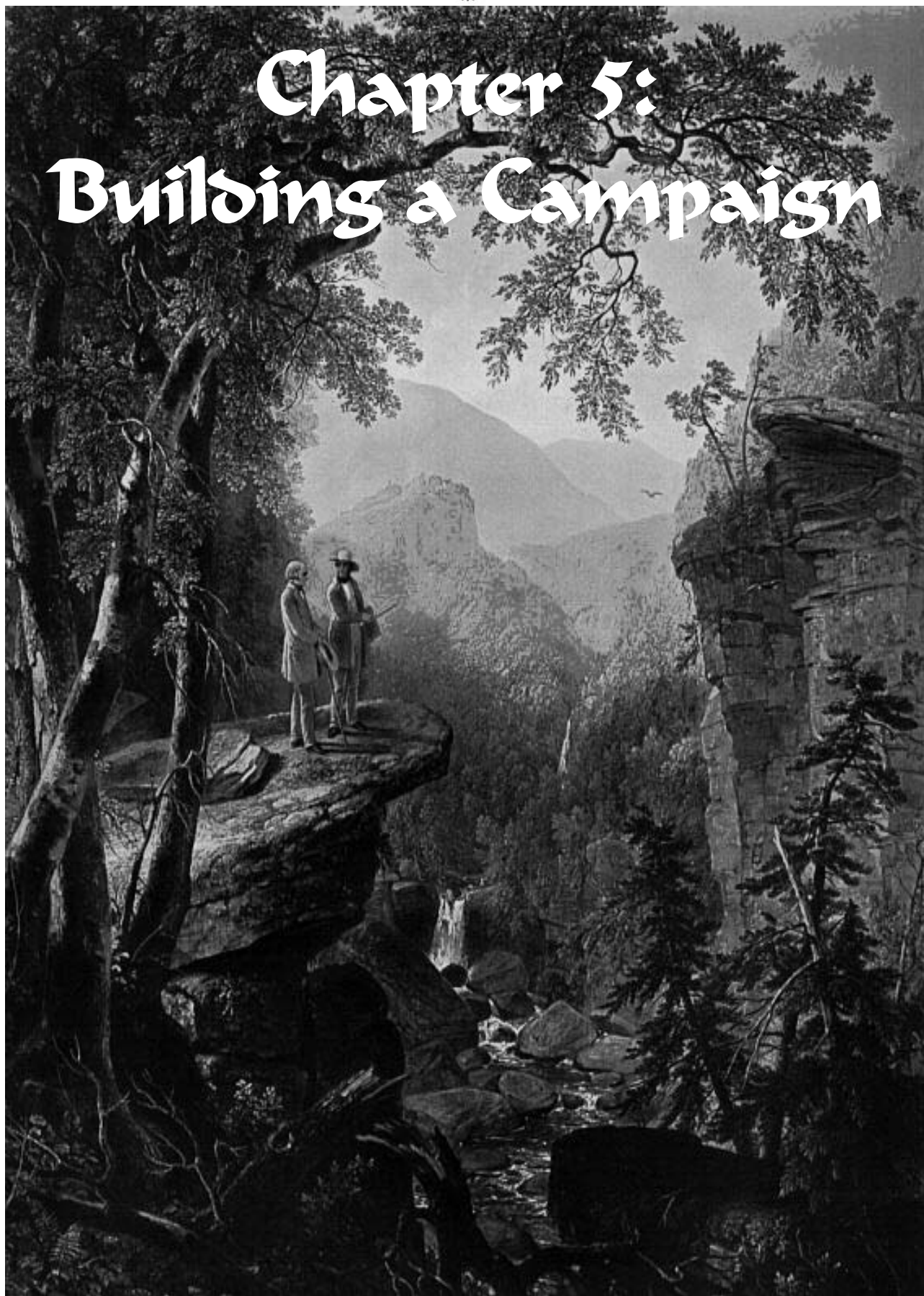




Chapter 5: Building a Campaign



CHARACTER TRAITS

Classical mythology and fantasy is full of tests of will and character. Will the hero persevere, give into fear, resist temptation, remain faithful, or be merciful? Is he or she truly worthy?

Unfortunately, in d20 (and in most other RPG's) the answer is almost always "of course!" If the players are warned of dire consequences if they turn around while leaving the land of the dead, their characters won't do it no matter what the Game Master says about noises and doubts. Why should they? It's not like the long trek, the awful cries, and the footsteps behind them are preying on the *player's* nerves - and it's the players who make the decisions.

The Game Master may attempt to arrange "tests" in advance; but this simply frustrates some players, confuses others, and leads to arguments. Someone always manages to totally misunderstand the test and players never do any of the things you thought they would anyway.

Character traits are for games where the game-master wants psychological tests and temptations to actually mean something. They describe a character's personality and act as a set of general guidelines for roleplaying, a way to measure a character's level of attunement to whatever higher or lower powers a world may boast, a way to tell if a character is "worthy" of wielding particular items, and provide something to roll against when a player is in doubt or when a character is faced with a psychological test.

For example, taking a blow unflinchingly requires a *Valorous* check, using a Healing Cup requires *Merciful* 15+, and resisting the temptation of Orpheus requires a *Steadfast* check. In general, the player may apply the character's (Wis Mod + 1, 1 minimum) to such checks to modify them up or down as desired. The GM may also modify the basic 21 DC based on circumstances; it's easier to resist a small bribe than a massive fortune. Player characters may, of course, defy the results of a trait roll, but this will cost them one action point or the loss of a point from the trait in question.

Traits come in linked pairs; if the value of opposed trait is desired it can be calculated at (21-Value, one minimum). Traits may either be selected by the player, or rolled like the other attributes - in which case the trait rolled for in each pair is up to the player. Any trait at 15+ is quite noticeable.

Cultural origins commonly modify traits; cultures tend to encourage or discourage various behaviors, resulting in modifiers of up to + or -2 on 2-5 traits selected by the GM.



Characters who were brought up following a particular faith or philosophy may add a +2 bonus to the value of the relevant traits.

Traits may also be raised or lowered by spending 1 CP per point of change desired. While this can be done at any time it's quite unusual for characters to change their traits by more than a few points per level this way.

Characters who consistently use their Wisdom modifiers to favor a particular trait may, at the option of the Game Master, gain a free point in that trait when they next gain a level. For example, if Friar Adric is consistently trying to overcome his cautious nature (Caution 14), the next time he gains a level he may well drop to Caution 13 - and rise to Valorous 8.

Magic affects traits roughly twice as strongly as it affects the more definite attributes. This is best used with caution; a "Ring of +8 Valor" could be a boon or a deadly curse depending on the circumstances.

The basic trait pairs for most settings include :

Altruistic	/	Selfish
Chaste	/	Hedonistic
Cultured	/	Barbaric
Curious	/	Focused
Energetic	/	Apathetic
Enthusiastic	/	Steadfast
Faithful (or Loyal)	/	Treacherous
Forgiving	/	Vengeful
Helpful	/	Argumentative
Honest	/	Manipulative
Leader	/	Follower
Merciful	/	Cruel
Modest	/	Proud
Mystic	/	Worldly
Objective	/	Prejudiced
Open	/	Secretive
Optimistic	/	Pessimistic
Organized	/	Anarchic
Patient	/	Restless
Physical	/	Cerebral
Principled	/	Expedient
Sociable	/	Antisocial
Stoic	/	Expressive
Temperate	/	Indulgent
Trusting	/	Suspicious
Valorous	/	Cautious

While there are many other possible pairs of traits, those cover things in most settings. Horror settings may want to add a Sanity / Madness trait. If so, we suggest starting the Sanity trait off with a substantial bonus. Rolling for sanity randomly doesn't seem like a good idea.



Granted Powers

Optionally, a setting's higher and lower powers may each be associated with a set of 3 to 6 Traits. Characters with an average score of 16+ in those traits will attract the notice of those powers, gaining (number of associated traits) x (average score -15) CP worth of special abilities provided by the power in question. In general, it's fair enough to let the player choose from whatever the powers offer.

For Example:

Hargrim is a citizen of the Elari Isles. Originally settled by refugees from the fall of Kirall, the Elari tend to be a bit short, sturdy, stoic, and self-reliant. Thanks to the poor soil and limited resources of the Isles they have come to value hard work greatly, but are suspicious of strangers. Elari have a +2 modifier to *Stoic* and *Suspicious* along with +1 modifiers to *Physical* and *Energetic*. They're inclined to rough humor and long hours.

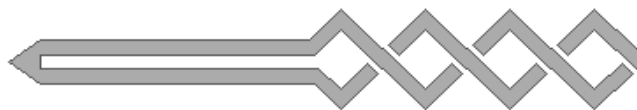
Hargrim was educated by the monks of Amitrage, an order devoted to the service of Mithris the Light-bringer, patron of Paladins and Guardian of Mankind. Being brought up in the faith, Hargrim gains a +2 modifier on his *Altruistic*, *Merciful*, and *Valorous* traits.

Some years later Hargrim has achieved an average score of 16 in Mithris's favored traits: *Altruistic*, *Faithful*, *Honest*, *Merciful*, *Physical*, and *Valorous*. Well pleased with such a splendid example of a mortal knight, Mithris grants Hargrim a bit of aid. The Game Master lets the player choose from among Mithris's possible gifts: Grant of Aid, Healing Touch (the Improved option is available for later), Companion (a noble steed), Augmented Bonus (Chr Mod adds to Str Mod when defending or aiding the innocent), and +6 CP worth of Channeling. If Hargrim should ever get his trait average up to 21 - a near-impossible feat - he will be have earned the entire package, and will doubtless be widely recognized as a paladin of Mithris.

Other gods, such as Elengil, god of Scholars and Magi, favor entirely different sets of virtues and grant entirely different sets of abilities. Elengil tends to favor *Curious*, *Mystic*, *Cerebral*, *Temperate*, *Organized* and *Treacherous*. He usually grants the ability to read languages and magic, various Metamagic Theorems, Mana, bonuses to Knowledges, and Augmented (Sneak) Attack.



Later on, his motivations grew more complex.



Motivations

Every character needs something beyond the basic statistics sheet. They need motivations and history - a reason to be involved, to be out adventuring instead of safe at home. Some common motivations are listed below; we recommend starting with a one major motivation and two or three secondary ones. There will be plenty of time for adding complications later on.

Accomplishing a Quest, Mission, or Oath – is there something specific you need to do or have you dedicated yourself to an open-ended mission?

Being the Best in a Field or the First to do something – is there something you need to succeed at?

Vengeance, Death, Hatred, or Chaos – is there a single driving force that forces the character onward? Is it an elemental force, or something personal? Is there anything you would not do in it's pursuit?

Service to a God, Order, Lord, or even Humanity in general – is there someone you obey implicitly, or do you use your own judgement in deciding where your efforts can be best applied?

Wealth, Power, Prestige, or even the Possession of a particular item or items – what do you want to get?

Knowledge, Research, Enlightenment, Mystic Lore – what do you want to know?

Honor, Reputation, Glory, Excitement, or Virtue – what do you want to be known for? Must others know, or is it enough for you to know yourself?

Find the Truth or Uncover a Mystery – are you looking for answers? Do you simply pursue the unknown for it's own sake?

Love, Companionship, Loyalty, Family, or Faith – whom do you need to protect? Are you still looking?

Survival, Escape, Redemption, or Unjust Pursuit – is something chasing you? Is it justified?

Unwanted Power, Obligation, Artifact, or Destiny – is your blood, a possession, or some power forcing you to take this path?

Reclaim a Heritage, Liberation, or Ascension – is there something you need to do or become?

Wanderlust, Travel, Exploration, or Discovery – do you just like adventure or do you feel compelled to push the frontiers outward?

Creation, Art, Teaching, Building for the Future – what is your legacy for tomorrow?

Habit, Instinct, or Compulsion – have you known any other life?

Herkan the Swordsman, unjustly accused of assassinating Earl Caderman, wishes above all to clear his name and return home to his family a free man. Second to that, he also wants to find glory and evade his pursuers.

The Sorcerer Marius wants to avenge her teacher, slain by a demon sent by the terrible dark lord Mar Kris, by slaying both Kris and the demon assassin. Yet she does not realize this quest will involve the secrets of her own ancestry and the power in her bloodline.

Ragnar the Berserker is driven by his rage and the bloodthirsty nature of his accursed enchanted battleaxe; he seeks peace, but it never lasts for long. Fate and his own uncontrollable battle-fury and barbaric excesses always drive him on.

Merilla, priestess of the Holy Earth Shrine, wants to rescue her younger brother and reclaim the Valin Forest from the horde of monsters that have seized it and corrupted the land. Secretly, she blames herself for fleeing, rather than fighting an impossible battle when the monsters came.

Complexity can come later, if at all. A few good sentences will suffice to start with - and may be the better idea at least at first, since it allows the player to concentrate on the important stuff. Players should also check with the Game Master as well as the other players before beginning, to avoid strained party relationships and intra-party conflicts. Fugitives from the law and dedicated enforcers of it rarely work well together, and there may well be no dragon of the icy wastes for you to devote your life to slaying. Things can often be worked out (perhaps the character is really innocent and the dedicated enforcer is trying to help prove it) but sometimes there is no help for it save starting over ("No, you cannot have a plasma rifle! We are playing fantasy today!").

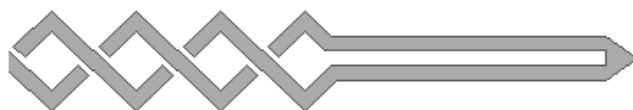
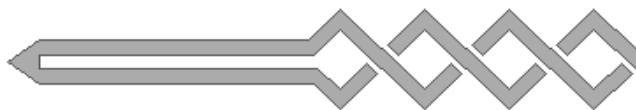
Characters who are pursuing a motivation other than "getting richer and more powerful" are usually eligible for some sort of bonus. After all, they're both making the Game Master's life easier and roleplaying - and isn't that what the game is all about?

Possibilities along this line include:

- A morale bonus. Detectives pursuing the solution to a mystery, romantics sneaking into the fortress to rescue their true loves, and faithful followers pursuing the will of their god would all gain a +2 morale bonus on attacks, damage, saves, and checks while doing so.
- Simply awarding experience points based on pursuing goals, rather than on defeating opponents. Of course, this removes a lot of the game's focus on combat.
- Allowing characters to purchase abilities that can only be used in pursuit of their motivations as Specialized.
- Allowing each character to spend a few Action Points using the *Heroism* or *Stunt* options (page 23) each game session when they're pursuing their motivations.

Now that your character has some personality traits and motivations, it's time to consider his or her ethics.





Character Profiles



Where will you go from here?

Civilizations often argue (internally and externally) about ethics: what is and what is not Good, Evil, Honorable, Courageous, Law-Abiding, and so on, in various situations. These questions have been asked for millennia and will continue to be asked for many more. Despite the publication of thousands of learned volumes of philosophy, theology, morality, and law, people have yet to come to an agreement.

We're not going to try to settle it here either, and a point-based game may have no great pantheons which care to enforce their notions on the topic. The questions in the character profile are intended to act as a guide to a character's general behavior - how they go about doing things. Why they do it is a topic for motivations, above.

To use the quiz simply move down the list of questions and answer them, adding up the numbers to the right of your responses as you go. You might want to put the questions and answers on the back of your character sheet. The results should suggest, but don't dictate, a character's alignment.

- *When would you break your word?*

- (+2) Not in the very face of death.
- (+1) It's become one hell of a pain.
- (+0) It's really inconvenient or expensive.
- (-1) It's something of a bother.
- (-2) Who needs a reason?

Personal loyalties and enmities may shift this rating up or down a notch. People will go to more trouble for someone they feel loyal to, but far less for an enemy.

- *When would you torture someone?*

- (+2) The very idea is unthinkable repellent.
- (+1) Only if the situation is absolutely desperate.
- (+0) It's a routine police procedure.
- (-1) I need to make a point.
- (-2) Whenever I felt like it.

Social attitudes may shift this rating up or down a notch. For example, someone who would normally have to be "desperate" to use torture might routinely use it to discipline slaves and yet would *never* torture a priest. Similarly, even individuals who would never normally advocate torture might stoop to using it against an outcast to prevent a major catastrophe.

- *Lying is...*

- (+2) An ineradicable stain upon one's very soul.
- (+1) A shameful last resort.
- (+0) Something to avoid if at all possible.
- (-1) An easy way to smooth things over.
- (-2) One of the best ways to manipulate people.

This often goes up or down a notch depending on the general seriousness of the situation and whether or not you respect the people you're dealing with.

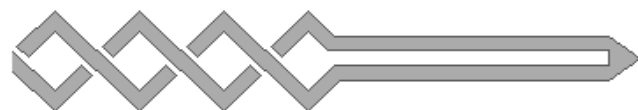
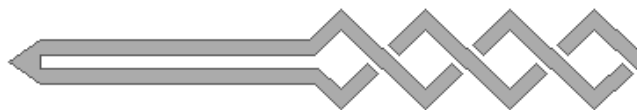
- *Your reputation and social status is...*

- (+2) More important than my life. I could never let an insult or slander pass.
- (+1) A big part of my self image. Never be shamed.
- (+0) Of some importance.
- (-1) Only my friends' opinions are of any import.
- (-2) Who cares what anyone else thinks?

This tends to go down when you're abroad. When you're at home, especially in those cultures which are based on "shame" rather than conscience, it may rise. Quite a few people regard glory and fame as major goals.

- *What are you looking for in life?*

- (+2) Virtue, Honor, and Service are their own rewards.
- (+1) Knowledge and Art are the highest of callings.
- (+0) Family, Friends, and Community are to be sought
- (-1) Pleasure and Security are my rewards.
- (-2) Wealth and power are what is truly real.



When you've truly, and securely, achieved one goal, shift one up. If you're deprived and despondent, shift one down. Starving people usually don't worry too much about art or honor. Perhaps fortunately, nobody ever has "enough" Virtue, Honor, and Service.

● *When would you betray or abandon a family member, close friend, companion, liege, or ally?*

- (+2) I care not if he has turned to the Dark Side!
- (+1) They did something unspeakably horrible.
- (+0) It's absolutely vital.
- (-1) It's important.
- (-2) It's convenient.

This is usually shifted by a step by their attitude towards you. Loyalty tends to reinforce itself, as does its lack. More obviously, short-term allies are a lot easier to abandon than long-term friends and companions.

● *You would defy the local laws and authorities...*

- (+2) Under no circumstances. The law is the law.
- (+1) On behalf of a higher cause (Justice, Mercy).
- (+0) For honor, duty, or (major) personal motives.
- (-1) For money, power, or other personal benefits.
- (-2) For the fun of it.

This tends to be shifted up or down by the severity of the consequences, and by how much respect you have for the authority in question. Trivial penalties usually shift it down a notch, severe ones raise it. People are more willing to defy the local etiquette maven on manners than an angry god on religious doctrine.

● *Success can best be achieved through...*

- (+2) Careful planning and organization. It's foolish to gamble more than you must.
- (+1) Planning and organization are important - but I have to be ready to seize opportunities.
- (+0) Nobody can plan for everything. I must be ready to improvise when things change.
- (-1) Sketching in broad outlines is good, but trying to make detailed plans is a waste of time.
- (-2) It's the long odds that offer great rewards. Go with the flow of events.

This is usually modified by how much time you've got available. Plenty usually moves it up a notch, but when you're really pressed for time you just can't afford to plan as thoroughly as you'd like, shift it down.

● *How much attention do you pay to faith and religion?*

- (+2) It is the duty of every man to serve the gods.
- (+1) They set ideals, but everyone fails at times.
- (+0) I set some time aside for them every week.
- (-1) Don't we support priests for that?
- (-2) I look after myself and don't bother them. They should look after the universe and not bother me.

While some characters follow philosophical paths or vaguely-defined "greater powers," most fantastic worlds have fairly obvious gods and religions. Atheism is rare in fantasy settings - although one can claim that the known gods aren't truly "divine" (whatever "divine" is). Unlike most personality traits, religion commonly varies by +/-2 or more under extreme stress or when the character is heavily involved in worldly affairs.

● *The welfare of other people is...*

- (+2) More important than my own welfare.
- (+1) Just as important as my own welfare.
- (+0) An important factor in your decisions.
- (-1) Nice if it's not too big a bother.
- (-2) Irrelevant. Why should I care about anyone but ME?!

Relationships may shift this character rating up or down a notch. People will generally go to more trouble for a child or relative than for someone who's simply a member of a group - and generally choose the welfare of their group over that of foreigners.

● *Tradition is...*

- (+2) The pillar that upholds the world against chaos.
- (+1) An anchor that keeps one from drifting about.
- (+0) An important guide to life.
- (-1) The voice of experience, if old-fashioned.
- (-2) Nothing but fossilized thinking.

Tradition is a wonderful anchor for group identity. Beleaguered, prosecuted, or minority factions (at least those groups who see themselves that way) tend to cling to it desperately. It does tend to break down among the young or in times of great change. Oddly enough, minor traditions are often the most durable and fiercely clung to.

● *The best way to achieve a widespread goal is...*

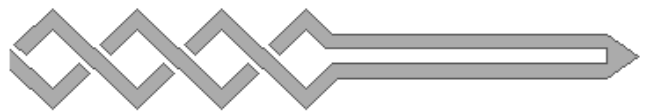
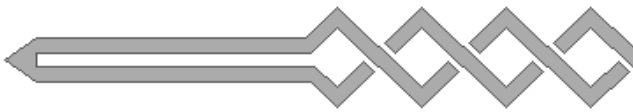
- (+2) Authoritarian or Divine Rule.
- (+1) A tightly-knit organization with set rules.
- (+0) Getting a large but loose association together.
- (-1) Starting a "grass-roots movement."
- (-2) Inspiring, skillful individuals who can go out and get things moving without wasting more time!

Surprisingly enough, this doesn't shift around very much. Those who believe in organization and groups or in individualism tend to work that way in almost any situation that doesn't obviously require the opposite approach.

● *Issues, competitions, and conflicts should be...*

- (+2) Contested openly, fairly, and with courtesy.
- (+1) Taking full advantage of my opponent's errors.
- (+0) Manipulation is a part of the game.
- (-1) Everybody cheats a bit, and so do I.
- (-2) Winning is what's important. Be expedient.





This tends to shift a bit depending on the stakes and on the consequences of getting caught cheating. A knife fight in a dark alley tends to override scruples, while poetry competitions usually don't. Oddly enough though, it rarely shifts by more than +/-1.

● *Power...*

- (+2) Corrupts. It must be used with caution and should be laid aside as soon as the crisis is past.
- (+1) Is dangerous. It should be used with restraint and wisdom - and as little as possible.
- (+0) Comes with an equal measure or responsibility.
- (-1) Comes with many cool perks.
- (-2) Is there to be used and enjoyed. Responsibility is a myth invented by the powerless.

Power is always a dilemma; the ramifications of any action are almost impossible to predict. Does one act and accept the risk, or wait and see? Oddly enough, those who acquire power often find their actions sliding down the scale, while those born to it are more aware of the limitations of their knowledge.

● *How often do you take time off?*

- (+2) What's this "Time Off" you speak of? Legacies require constant work and self-discipline.
- (+1) I have to relax at times or I'll go nuts, but I'm building a better life for my kids.
- (+0) Everybody indulges a little sometimes.
- (-1) I work hard, I play hard. You take what fun you can find in life, a vacation renews the soul.
- (-2) Life is short. Party on!

Sheer dedication has much to do with accomplishment, although judgment, skill, and even luck also influence it. Still, the level of stress involved often shifts this up or down a notch.

● *How important to you are your possessions?*

- (+2) Material possessions are of no consequence.
- (+1) Be practical. You gotta have tools and supplies.
- (+0) My souvenirs have great sentimental value.
- (-1) You're nobody unless you're a man of property.
- (-2) Life's not worth living without a few luxuries.

Curiously enough, whether or not someone can afford it rarely has much influence on their possessiveness or generosity - only on its scale.

● *Fools, Criminals, and Enemies should be dealt with using...*

- (+2) Patience and persuasion.
- (+1) Conversion, firmness, and pressure.
- (+0) Firm legal and social control.
- (-1) Sterilization and/or enslavement.
- (-2) Fear and extermination.

Due to the wide variation in the definition of "Fools,

Criminals, and Enemies," this can get tricky. In the end, quite a variety of methods work reasonably well, but no entirely satisfactory system has yet been found. This tends to vary a bit depending on how potentially valuable the targets appear.

● *Strangers and Foreigners are...*

- (+2) People, to be respected and trusted unless they prove unworthy.
- (+1) Possibly odd, but generally decent enough.
- (+0) To be treated with respect, but caution.
- (-1) Untrustworthy, and likely inferior. Respect must be earned.
- (-2) Resources, to be exploited.

Attitudes towards those outside a group - like those towards "Fools, Criminals and Enemies," above - tend to have less social impact than behavior patterns directed towards those within it. On the other hand, they vary a lot less. After all, if you knew them well, they'd be a part of your social group.

"Minor Traits" have relatively little social impact, and so are not rated, but they do add some detail to your character's personality. What does your character love? Like? Dislike? Hate? Do when bored? Enjoy Eating? Flesh out a character by giving him or her some everyday traits.

Interpreting the Profile

Like most high-level abstractions the simple scale given below is quite generalized. Positive scores have been assigned to behaviors that promote long-term group survival and negative ones to behaviors that benefit the individual at the expense of the group. Naturally enough, surviving groups tend to be those which promote and encourage "positive" traits as desirable and good while discouraging the "negative" ones as irresponsible, undesirable, or even evil.

This isn't an ironclad principle. "Negative" traits occasionally prove highly effective, especially in emergencies, and so retain an equilibrium frequency in the population. It's just not a good idea to overdo them. Similarly, an excess of positive traits is good for your group - but may be very bad for you. Martyrdom is not a career choice with long-term prospects.

- 27 to 34: You are principled and scrupulous beyond all expectations. If you actually manage to live up to this you're a likely candidate for sainthood - if your companions let you live that long. "Holy" items will respond to you with enthusiasm.
- 18 to 26: You are noble and honorable. You have a few flaws, but you'd make a splendid Arthurian knight.

- 08 to 17: You're an upstanding citizen.
- 07 to -7: You are about average. Your scruples and principles will often take second place to expedience and survival, but you're basically decent enough.
- -8 to -17: You may have many attractive traits - but you're generally considered something of a scoundrel.
- -18 to -25: You're often unwelcome or disruptive in a group, but they'll turn to you when someone needs a bit of dirty work done.
- -26 to -34: Congratulations! You apparently have few, perhaps no, redeeming features as far as functioning in your group is concerned. Unless your talents are both exotic and utterly indispensable no sane group will put up with you for long.



**Rostav began to regret becoming a priest...
of the god of Male Pattern Baldness.**

Profiles are not static - although it's rare for one to change abruptly. Youthful optimism, flexibility, and impatience tend to give way to cynicism or rigidity with age, while life and experience drive unpredictable changes in other attitudes.

Major, rapid profile changes are usually the result of equally major traumas or transcendent experiences. Others, of course, simply find a reaffirmation of what they already are under such circumstances. In either case, an experience that profound should either change her profile or reinforce her previous traits.

Character Description

Background material doesn't have game mechanics, but it's at least as important as the items which do. A character without a background is only half complete.

Character descriptions should always include the basics - a name, title, or alias, general concept, species (if more than one is allowed), some plot hooks to draw the character into adventures and - perhaps most vitally - both a reason for staying with the group and a reason for the group to want to keep them around. Characters lacking any of these elements should be rejected out of hand.

Give at least a bit of consideration to:

Physical Elements: What will people see when they glance at you? General height, build, coloration, age, gender facial "cast," and other distinguishing features go here as well as any personal symbols, and how the character dresses and acts.

-Pictures are very helpful here if the player is any good as an artist or can simply find one they like.

Mental Elements: What will people find out if they talk to you? Minor quirks and/or behavioural tags, simple, ordinary, things the character likes to do for fun, would go well out of their way for, or just can't stand, hobbies, personal loyalties, quotes, and fears and the belief system the character subscribes to all go here.

Social Elements: What will people find out if they ask around about you? Items such as how other people tend to see the character, family, friends and relatives, lovers, children, siblings, parents, spouses, and other major involvements all go here. This may include memberships in organizations, legal status, legitimacy, clan membership, your reputation, and any traits you're known for - such as those with scores of 15+.

Historical Elements: What will people find out if they investigate your past? The character's place of birth, how he or she acquired or discovered his or her talents and skills, education or teachers, major turning points in the characters life - whether triumphs, discoveries, or tragedies - portents or omens and prophecies involving you (If any), previous jobs, old companions (and why you're no longer with them), your personal secrets or guilts, and where you were raised all go here.

-Your family - who they were, what they did, whether you're like them or not - is a good place to start.

Current Affairs include where, if anywhere, you live at the moment, how the character sees him- or herself (And what he or she would say his or her occupation is), any usual hangouts, your adventuring and civilian personas (if different), sexual preference, and any current mysteries or ongoing plots and schemes.

World Construction

So you've got a clever idea for making a world. You have a grand and glorious vision of such awesome depth and emotional power that people will flock for just a peek, and you – in your infinite kindness – have chosen to deliver this vision unto the players in your usual game.

Well, you've got a few options now. You can just use the rules as presented, or you can start working on a World Template.

Like a template applied to a character, a World Template has simple, clear changes to the rules applied to the world in question.

In other words, they're packages of house rules designed to show players what kind of a world they're entering. Usually, Templates are built around a specific theme or style, and change the nature of the game to match. Instead of going from one fantasy universe with generic rules to another, you can customize your experience.

World Templates are not filled with descriptive material, only rules. There is a reason for this: anyone can say a thing is so, but it takes work to make it so. The World Template needs to reflect how the rules impact events, not how characters should feel about them. These Templates apply both to characters and NPC's equally, though some of them explicitly help the heroes more than the villains.

Sample World Templates

108 Stars of Destiny. The players may switch characters from the character pool as long as they play only one at a time and have time to switch. They may create more characters and add them to the group's pool between sessions; players may use any character, including those they didn't personally make. The selection should contain a healthy selection of people with useful non-combat skills and talents as well as combat-based characters. It is suggested that GM's limit the maximum character level.

Anime. In Anime, characters don't actually take damage. In fact, in order to kill anyone, characters must simply meet or exceed the target's maximum hit points in one hit. This makes it difficult to kill enemies. Don't worry too much about which active or offensive powers PC's have, and eliminate all maximums on buying abilities. Let them go wild. Watch the defensive powers PC's stack, and make sure they don't make themselves invulnerable.

Energetic. Characters start off with 1d6 Mana and gain +1d2 every four character levels (whenever they would gain an attribute point). This makes certain branches of magic easier, and allows even combat-oriented characters to use a decent spell now and then.



Planet under construction. Please pardon the mess.

Grim. Grim limits humans and humanoids to a maximum of 45 HP (characters can't take more than 1d6 per level). This roughly matches the heights of real human toughness.

Limit. This options simply limits the normal maximum character level to some arbitrary number. Level 10 is good for semi-realistic worlds, where characters must live by their wits. Some worlds may have limits for specific character races, classes, or abilities (limits to the number of points or effective user level). Templates can often go beyond the level limits.

Mass Murder. The characters have an infinite supply of goons to attack. In a world with this rule, the characters can wipe out whole segments of the population, only to see them return, mysteriously unharmed. This ensures an infinite supply of thugs for the villains. Powerful characters might even look into changing this law over the entire world. Remember, this isn't just a *convention*, it's an actual *law* of the universe, albeit one which presumably was created artificially.



Mini Mighty Monster. This World Template turns the game upside down. Whenever a character gains a level, he or she becomes a character of that level (and requires the normal amount of experience to gain another) but gains only 6 personal CP and no extra HP or bonus abilities, including skill points. In fact, they're always considered level 1.

The other 18 CP, and level-based bonuses, go to buying or enhancing Companions - although any single companion may not have more than 48 CP invested in him, her, or it. Sadly, for some strange reason, only one Companion may be active at once. This is a very strange World Template, but the genre *is* popular.

Natural Magic. Anyone, anywhere, can cast magic spells as per Natural Magic (Page 36). Treat this as divine spellcasting.

This works best with simple effects like *Burning Hands* - something that anyone can imagine in a pinch.

Penumbra. The Penumbra Template takes the already-powerful and makes them gods. Quite often literally. In Penumbra, there are no limits on what feats characters may or may not take, and how many of them they may take. Characters can apply flaws to every ability they choose to.

The more damage, the better. If one character ignores hit points and saves totally and concentrates solely on becoming the ultimate Thaumaturgy master, so be it.

It calls for a very good GM to steer the game and may require some amazingly powerful monsters, but it's actually quite fun every now and then. Everyone has a secret desire to become all powerful, and here's the chance. Strangely, after playing Penumbra once or twice, many players go on to try non-combat characters, like gadgeteers or bards.

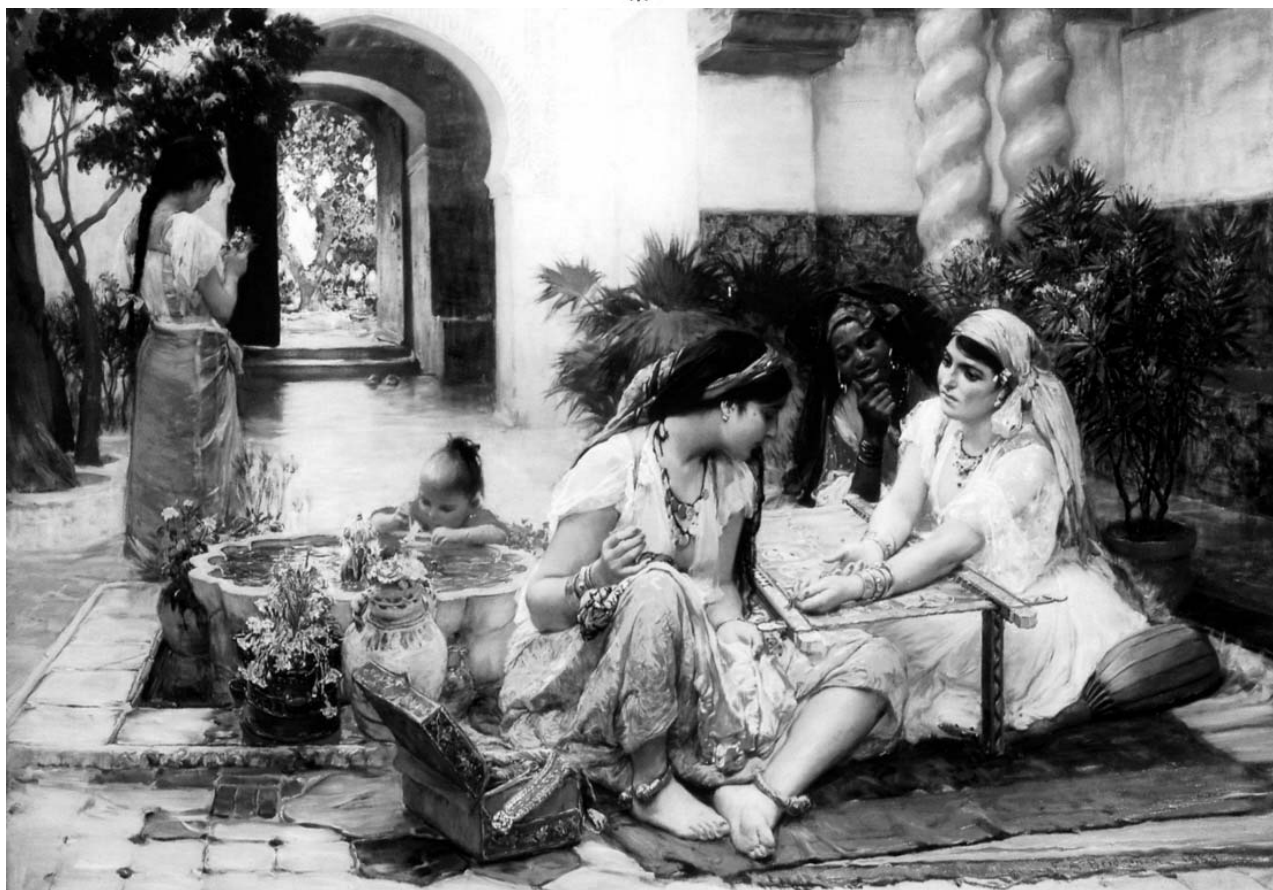
Power Sink. Powerful magic requires extra energy in this system. Specifically, characters can cast spells of level 0-2 without any extra juice. At levels 3-5, character must pay one extra Mana point or spell level, or 2 extra Power, to cast the spell. At levels 6-8, character must provide 2 extra Mana or spell levels, or 4 extra power. Level 9 spells require 3 Mana or Spells levels or 6 additional power. Power Sink rules make spellcasting difficult on the high end, but also means that it becomes impressive and rare again.

Wu Xia. In Wu Xia, characters split up their hit points. They choose part to go into Dodge Points and the rest remains hit points. The difference is this: DP are used up first, but exactly in the manner of hit points. DP return every time the character can rest for at least ten minutes.

Some spells and abilities can target HP directly, usually for a +5 level modifier on the spell level. For example, a 9th-level spell can deal direct HP damage as if it were a 4th-level spell. A special attack that works 1/day and allows the user to target hit points with his or her next blow costs 12 CP, +6 CP for every 1/day thereafter (do not use the normal Bonus Uses feat). Critical hits also go directly to HP.

Superheroic. Superheroic worlds are very simple. Each major character can spend (Con Mod) free points of Mana each round without drawing on their personal reserves - although they can't save up those points. They usually have some Damage Reduction as well, although often only to convert some lethal damage to stun. NPC's are usually either very low level (normal people) or of fairly high level (heroes and villains).

Once done choosing your world templates, all you have to do is decide what special paths (from Chapter 3) and basic feats you wish to leave out. Mystic Artist and Channeling are the only normal Paths. For abilities, just jot down a few that don't fit in the with the style of game you want - and note any which are secret techniques held by limited groups - and viola! One finished setting, ready to play.



Putting Your Players to Work

Let's say you get through your idea and select a Template and realize, "I want to play an iconic game with great warriors and wizards. I want characters to represent archetypes, not built on a player's passing whim!" Don't worry, cause we've got a solution for you. (You didn't think we'd waste your time here, eh?)

There's a lot of room in the archetypes for variability. After all, one can imagine a world where the Fighter is a butt-kicking knight-errant Paladin-lite, or a tough-as-nails desert soldier. Now, you probably don't want to go through and think up new ideas for every character class. But on the other hand, you might want new material.

So get your players together, pick out a bunch of ideas and archetypes, and simply hand them out. Everyone grabs a couple and writes up ideas and builds, at least out to level 10 or so. The players don't have to play the builds they develop. Instead, they hand them back and you sort through them, sort out what's useful and what's silly, and polish them off. Then you go back to the players with these and start the campaign.

If you're starting a spur-of-the-moment game, let everyone pick out a few abilities but hold off on anything deep, and play through. Next week, they can come back with some material.



You can even do this with magic systems. One old, but rarely used trick has the GM set up the game so the players are foreigners and don't understand the local magic. The GM defines the outcome of using spells. Let the players work through, building the magical principles (and rules and formula) as they go. Not only does this reduce the strain on you, but it involves each and every player in the process of world creation, and gives them a stake in it. All of this really helps breathe life into the campaign.

Keeping Characters Under Control

Here at Distant Horizons Games we're well aware that systems can be abused. It's inevitable in any system with many options, and certainly happens in d20. Rather than pretend it can't happen, we present this guide to keeping things under control. Characters can still be powerful - but they shouldn't be abusive about it. If someone makes a PC completely out of character for the game, then they need to rethink their build. Here are a few steps for getting them to do just that.

Some cruel GM's like to screw with the player first before delivering the final blow, taking away favorite toys first. But not everyone is that mean and we don't recommend it. Explaining rationally why they're spoiling the game works a great deal better than smiting them without explanation.

1) "No" is a powerful word. Every character should be examined and vetted regularly. Some players are simply willing to write powers and abilities down or conveniently "interpret" the rules. Somehow, they convince themselves they're not cheating everyone else. If they do, tell them "No." If they're making a character that does not fit into the world, tell them "No." If they're using or combining abilities in a way that you have doubts about, tell them "No."

"No" is a good thing. The fun is in trying to overcome obstacles, not in having omnipotence handed to you on a silver platter.

2) Bring in similar NPC's. If necessary, simply run two-level battles: a grossly powerful enemy for the abusive character or characters and normal ones for the rest of the party. Even if the abusive character loses, the grossly powerful enemies took enough damage to allow the reasonable PC's handle them or "their powers have been weakened" from the preceding part of the battle. And if you don't have any ideas, just copy the abusive character's sheet and add in another 2 levels' worth of abilities.

3) Assign ECL penalties to overly-powerful character designs. If they're more powerful than other characters of their level, then an ECL penalty is obviously in order.



**-20 Circumstance
Penalty on Read Lips.**

4) The Master Blaster Trick. Under these rules, forget about buying hit points for villains and monsters. They simply can fight for a number of turns or survive a certain number of attack actions. If the party (specifically, the non-abusive ones) is doing well, getting a bit lucky, figures out a good trick, or comes up with a good plan, then cut down on the villain's survival times. This actually works out roughly similar to playing with hit points, but keeps those few characters with massive attack abilities from dominating the fights. Just describe the villain's amazing (but limited-use defenses) that they only bring out against the massive attacks. If you want to take the time you can even just buy that for them.

5) The Booster Trick. Create a GM character who can boost other characters' abilities up to the level of the abusive ones. Furthermore, make this NPC vulnerable and restrict it by making those boosts unable to affect a character as powerful as the abusive ones. Now the party is all roughly in the same power level, and has a nice new dependant NPC to defend from monsters and villains.

6) Tell the player to stop using the abusive character. They're spoiling the game for everyone else. Conversely, if everyone is really having fun, it's probably not that abusive.

7) Decide that they, and no one else, must use standard builds or GM-made ones. The point-buy system can be reserved for people who don't abuse it.

8) Kill them. Why put up with deliberate sabotage?

9) The abusive character keeps running into evil twins. Don't bother running any actual battles for this; just assume the two of them fight it out for 2d6 hours. Then spend that time in-game playing with the normal, non-abusive characters and pay no attention to the abusive ones. Once it's over, give the abusive player a new chance to play it straight. If not, rinse and repeat until they get bored.

10) Allow the abusive character to gain omnipotence. No! Really! Hear us out! Let them gain omnipotence, then hand them any GM's notes you have, pull out *your* new character and ask them when you can join up with the rest of the party. No, we're not joking.

Sample Character Builds

These sample builds give you a further idea of the basics of making a character. While we don't go for an in-depth examination of attributes, equipment, skills, and spells, it does contain all the basics. Aside from that, these present useful character ideas if you just need a quick NPC or aren't sure what you want to play.

Sneak-Thief: Character Level 3

The Sneak-Thief is a cowardly figure with a pocket full of other people's money. How he or she got started adventuring is a total mystery, except possibly that sheer greed overrode common sense. While somewhat useless in a fight, the sneak-thief has some talents for getting out of trouble and a knack for lucky breaks. This is a pretty basic build; at higher levels many sneak-thieves rely as much on magical tricks as on skill. Others, especially in low-magic settings, simply rely on skill boosters and Mastery (for "Taking 10" on all those skills).

Available 96 CP (Base)

Hit Die: 3d4 (0 CP)

Saves: +5 (15 CP; +1 Fort, +3 Ref, +1 Will)

Warcraft: +1 (9 CP; the character will spend 3 CP next level to gain another +1)

Special Abilities: (18 CP) - Luck (Bonus Uses, 12 CP), Immunity/Divination (Uncommon/Major, 6 CP)

Proficiencies: All Simple Weapons, Light Armor (6 CP)

Skills: 48 skill points (48 CP; taking thieving, spying, and athletic skills)

Total: 96 CP out of 96

Desert Raider: Character Level 5

Desert Raiders live a precarious existence on the most marginal terrain – a frozen waste, a dry grassland, or a burning desert. Using the harshness of such lands to become strong, they prowl the land fiercely. Hunting for game or material wealth depending on where they find themselves – in the wastes or near settled areas – the desert raider strikes with fearsome swiftness. No caravan can cross their domains without either paying the tolls or risking a swift and merciless death at their hands.

Available 144 CP (Base)

Hit Die: 5d10 (30 CP)

Saves: +8 (24 CP; +4 Fort, +3 Ref, +1 Will)

Warcraft: +5 (30 CP)

Special Abilities: (15 CP) - Track (Wilderness, 3 CP), Traceless (Wastes, 6 CP), Reputation (Desert Warrior, 6 CP)

Proficiencies: All Simple and Martial weapons, Light Armor (12 CP)

Skills: 33 skill points (33 CP; taking sneaking and wilderness skills)

Total: 144 CP out of 144 CP.



Actually there's nothing wrong with it. But there's no penalty and the patch looks cool.

Mini-Monk: Level 8

So she's short. So she's not so good at getting along peacefully. She can kick butt, instead! The Mini-Monk is knows Kung-Fu and likes to hit people. Hard. Often. Aside from that, she has all sorts of tricks for not getting hit back, because she just doesn't fight fair. And every now and then, when she really needs it, she can just let it all out. All those years of being picked last in sports, of being laughed at for her size, of straining to reach the top cabinets – and its going to hurt somebody else this time. Fear the short one.

Available 216 CP (Base)

Hit Die: 8d4 (0 CP)

Saves: +12 (36 CP; +2 Fort, +5 Ref, +5 Will)

Warcraft: +8 (48 CP)

Special Abilities: (84 CP) Ambidexterity (6 CP), Acrobatics (6 CP), Odinnight Berserker: +16 to-hit and damage, +8 to AC (Specialized: only after being picked on for being short, 12 CP), Karma (6 CP), Defender (6 CP), Bonus Attack: with Quarterstaff (6 CP), Improved Imbuement (12 CP), Enhanced Strike: Crushing, Focused, Whirlwind, Hammer, Shattering (30 CP).

Proficiencies: All Simple Weapons (3 CP)

Skills: 45 skill points (45 CP)

Total: 216 CP out of 216 CP.



Ulric the Wanderer, Chosen of Fate: Level 8

Remember Ulric, back in the basics section on page 8? Here he is, a full-blown player-designed power build, just to horrify you.

Available 216 CP

Hit Dice: L1/d20 (16 CP), L2/d4 (0 CP), L3 to L8/d8 (Corrupted: magical healing only, multiply rolls by 1.5, 16 CP)

Saves: +4 each (Corrupted to +6; The bonuses don't work if the attacker knows his true name. 36 CP)

That was a bit cheap, but I, as the Game Master, did say that characters would be magically vulnerable to opponents who knew their true names, and this is an acceptable mechanism. I pointed it out to everyone else of course - and used it on the NPC's as well.

Warcraft: +4 (24 CP)

Proficiencies: Simple Weapons and Bows (6 CP)

Skills: 23 CP.

This was pretty minimal, but between two levels of Adept and enhancing an already-high Intelligence, Ulric wound up with plenty of skill points anyway.

Magic Levels: 8 (12) Levels of Alchemical Hedge Magician (page 22, 8 CP) plus Base Caster Level 8 (Specialized; only with Alchemical Hedge Magician, and subject to the same limitations. Specialized and Corrupted again. 8 CP).

That was a stretch. I ruled that only one level of Specialization applied in this case, and upped the cost to 16 CP. Still a bargain, though.

Special Abilities: Immunity To Aging (0 CP for a basic campaign), Self-Development (+2 Int with regard to Skills, 6 CP), Adept (Healing skills, buys Physician, Herbalist, Alchemy and Diplomacy skills at half cost, 6 CP), Adept (Scholar, buys Knowledge, Spellcraft, and Sense Motive skills at half cost, 6 CP), Augmented Bonus: Int Mod to AC (Specialized; only while wielding a staff, 3 CP), Augmented Bonus (Int Mod to Str Mod/Melee Bonus. Specialized; Only while wielding a staff, 3 CP), Reflex Training (Bonus Spellcasting action. Ride The Dragon abilities only, only when channeled thru a staff, 3 CP), and Grant of Aid (6 CP).

Given an Intelligence-boosting item, two level gain bonuses added to Intelligence, and an 18 to start with, Ulric was pretty dangerous in a fight. In fact, he tended to operate more as a warrior than a mage.

The Dragon Path: Shaping and Heart of the Dragon (L0 and L1. Corrupted; Requires gestures and minor special effects. 16 CP), Charmsmith, Spellforging, and Dragonsmith (Arms and Armor) (18 CP). Eye of the Dragon (Three times, 18 CP), Dragonfire (6 CP), Pulse of the Dragon (Corrupted; Maximum of 1/minute, 4 CP), Ride The Dragon (III, 18 CP; Ulric took a bunch of very convenient low-level spells, including curative magic, skill boosters, and some especially designed to boost his staff-fighting and defensive skills - extra attacks, damage and AC boosts).

Level-Based Bonus Feats (Effectively 6 CP each): Fast Learner (Specialized: The Dragon Path), Mana (Spell Enhancement option), Hysteria (Magic), and Cloaking (seems to be a minor herb mage at most).

Duties: Gets mysterious missions and assignments from his magical patrons and/or wyrd. +2 CP/Level

Disadvantages (10 Points): History, Hunted (crazed cultists, horrors from beyond) overblown sense of responsibility, partial amnesia (doesn't remember his full history - or most of his enemies), Secret (Immortal mage-guardian).

Actually that's two gratuitous disadvantages, since only the first three count for getting points, but that's to the GM's advantage anyway.

Total: 258 CP. Available 216 CP (Base) + 16 CP (Duties) + 16 CP (Fast Learner) + 10 CP (Disads) = 258 CP.

Ulric was an extremely versatile minor magician, a superb staff-fighter as long as his magic reserve held out (and a fair one after that), and turned out to be extremely durable. That was a good thing for him, since the campaign only allowed limited healing magic and did not allow resurrections of any kind.

Thanks to his Duties and list of Disadvantages he also proved to be an endless source of plotoooks and adventures - and his strong mythic background brought a lot of depth to the game. Cutting the players a bit of slack for their characters can be pretty rewarding.

Scholarly Dweomerist: Character Level 12

Some people can't stand a mystery they can't solve. The Dweomerist can't stand the mystery of matter, and wants to find out exactly what it is. Depending on the universe he or she hails from, this could take a very, very long time, or might be finished before lunchtime. Either way, he or she also gains impressive powers of matter control, thoroughly enjoying the ability to transform or manipulate it as he or she pleases. While flexible, the Scholarly Dweomerist tends to be a bit low in the raw power department - but is capable of powerful, if poorly-controlled, feats of magic in a true emergency.

Available 312 CP (Base)

Hit Die: 12d4 (0 CP)

Saves: +12 (36 CP; +0 Fort, +0 Ref, +12 Will)

Warcraft: +6 (36 CP)

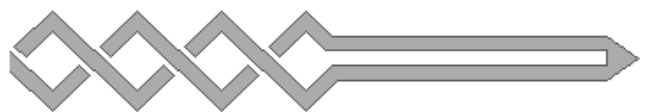
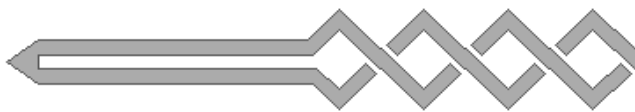
Feats: (66 CP) - Adept x2 (For his or her dweomer field skills, 12 CP), Thaumaturgy (6 CP), Researcher (Analyst upgrade, 12 CP), Mana (8d6, 42 CP), Hysteria (Magic, Mighty upgrade, 12 CP), 2x Professional Skills (favored magical techniques, 12 CP).

Magic Levels: 12 Caster Levels (Dweomer Only, 36)

Proficiencies: All Simple Weapons (3 CP)

Skills: 108 skill points (108 CP)

Total: 312 CP out of 312 CP.



Mormvandus: Character Level 18

Guardian of the Dead, the First Warrior, Balancer of the Scales, Protector of Moæiä, Keeper of Knowledge, Lord of the Seas and Winds

Mormvandus is like a Greek God. In fact, he IS a god! He got into the professional god business some time ago, grabbing up several juicy Spheres of Influence while they were still open. He has a rather high opinion of himself, but he figures he earned it, and enjoys helping out heroes now and then. On the downside, Mormvandus has a nasty temper when he doesn't get his way, and tends to raise up mountains and send tornadoes around until someone does what he wants.

Despite being a power build, Mormvandus is tolerably versatile, although his specialties are time and negative energy magic.

Mormvandus is a power build within the normal rules. Designed to be a major opponent for entire parties, he can quite possibly win. As a matter of fact, Mormvandus almost certainly will win if he needs to, because he has Godfire. On the other hand, Godfire isn't terribly common, so it's best to leave it alone unless the need is great. Just as importantly, since he normally pays for his Theurgy with Body Fuel, major spellcasting will leave him drained for some time. That's why he limits his interventions. Of course, he generally doesn't show up without several enhancing and protective spells running on top of his magic item collection.

The Divine Infusion feat he's got gives him a major boost in character points, and some, if only by accident, have to arrive somewhere useful.

Available 456 CP (Base)

Hit Die: 1d20 +2d6 +17d4 (20 CP)

Saves: +25 (75 CP; +8 Fort, +5 Ref, +12 Will)

Warcraft: +13 (78 CP)

Special Abilities: 162 CP. Adept 2 (Theurgy, the six Verbs, Illusion [negative energy aspect] and Time, 12 CP), Fast Learner (Specialized in SP for theurgy, 6 CP), Augmented Bonus (Int to Theurgy Skills, 12), Self Development (+6 Int for skill points for theurgy and for theurgy skills, 36 CP), Efficient Body Fuel: Versatile, Kundalini Upgrade (24 CP), Manipulation (6 CP), Sphere of Influence (War, Death, Knowledge, Weather, 24 CP), Godfire (6 CP), Minions (6 CP), Creation (6 CP), Divine Infusion (6 CP), Soulshield (6 CP), and 2d6 Mana (Spell Enhancement option, 12 CP).

Magic Levels: 20 Caster Levels (Theurgy only, 60 CP)

Proficiencies: Simple Weapons (3 CP)

Skills: 94 skill points (94 CP) - plus, of course, quite a few from Fast Learner and his enhanced Intelligence.

Total: 492 CP out of 492 CP (456 CP [Base] + 36 CP [Duties; originally to a mystical order, currently to the rest of the pantheon]).

The Foot of Doom: Character Level 20

And Yea, the Foot cometh right hard, and sweepeth away all upon the path, and obliterating with great stomps, it cleareth the field. And Yea, mine eyes have seen the Foot, for it is evil. When cometh the Foot, let all ye powerful bow down and recognize the Foot's dominance, Yea, it shall surely smite those who doeth it not. And stomping them, it crusheth their bones to tiny pieces, and then feasts.

The Foot of Doom is purely and simply silly. It's a power build designed to need no equipment to kill people. And that's all it does. It randomly shows up and blasts the intestinal contents of the chosen victim everywhere. The Foot of Doom is essentially the GM's shotgun, applicable to any ultimate opposition the GM wishes to use.

And when we say ultimate, we mean it. This thing can teleport in, hit *11 times* on a full action, all as touch attacks, deals at least 1d20+(Hysteria Str Mod)+12d6, keeps fighting long after dying, and will come back even if killed. Since with karma and luck it should never miss, that means the Foot of Doom is something akin to a magical ballistic missile, dishing out an average 621.5 damage, not counting actual attributes or any other bonuses. We've seen players come up with even worse builds, but that's a lot of work to go to just for a "No."

Like we said, it's a ridiculous creature solely built to (a) demonstrate how far you can stretch the system, (b) just how boring it really is, and (c) make those player characters back way, way off from trying to power-game the GM.

Available 504 CP (Base)

Hit Die: 20d4 (0 CP)

Saves: +0 (0 CP)

Warcraft: +21 (126 CP)

Feats: 355 CP – Improved Karma (12 CP), Luck (Bonus Uses, 12 CP), Poison Use (6 CP), Unique Returning (18 CP), Stoic (Ferocity, Juggernaut, 15 CP), Blindfight 30' Darkvision (12 CP), Enhanced Attack (extra 12d6 damage when stomping on enemies, Silencing, 42 CP), Enhanced Strike (all, 36 CP), Favored Enemy (Player Characters, 6 CP), Superior Imbuement (Unarmed, 18 CP), Superior Rapid Strike (30 CP), Martial Arts d20 damage (21 CP), Spirit Weapon (Touch Attack all, Exotic Appearance, Unarmed attack as Giant Foot, 75 CP), Inherent Spell *Mirror Image* 4/day (Advanced, *Teleport*, 18 CP), Hysteria Strength (Corrupted: only when stomping, 4 CP),

Proficiencies: None (0 CP)

Skills: 26 skill points (26 CP, all in one martial art and Jump)

Total: 504 CP out of 504 CP.



The Living Destruction: Character Level 20

We'd like to write something cool for the Living Destruction, but it's nothing more than the Foot of Doom as a spellcaster. A horrible spellcaster. This isn't a character write-up, it's a cheat-sheet for GM's.

Available 504 CP (Base)

Hit Die: 20d4 (0 CP)

Saves: +0 (0 CP)

Warcraft: +0 (0 CP)

Magic Levels: 23 Sorcerer (extra restriction: conduct, 299 CP)

Feats: 200 CP - Amplify (6 CP), Area (6 CP), Elemental Manipulation (6 CP), Extension (6 CP), Lacing (6 CP), Multiple (6 CP), Sculpting (6 CP), Glory (18 CP), Streamline (6 CP), Fast (6 CP), Improved Initiative (12 CP), Evasive (Melee Spellcasting, 12 CP), Unity (6 CP), Theurgy (6 CP), Improved Stoic (Ferocity, Juggernaut, 21 CP), Spell Flow (6 CP), Returning (30 CP), Superior Power Words (Harbingers, Spellform, Sendings, 33 CP), and Luck with Bonus Uses (12 CP)

Proficiencies: None (0 CP)

Skills: 5 skill points (5 CP)

Total: 504 CP out of 504 CP.



You wouldn't like me when I'm angry.

ECLIPSE: THE CODEX PERSONA



Templates

The Faithful Steed

"To arms, Chevalier!

Eighteen hands high fights not alone,

Eyes alight with battle-lust.

With blade and hoof we strike as one,

Murderous, each battle-thrust.

About we lay, our lives entwined,

War in every pulsing breath.

The wicked barbs flow fore and hind,

Till all but we be dead and left.

The fight is won, though vict'ry hard

Our hearts beat wild and spry.

Few blows slipt through past our guard,

Bloodened brothers, Chevalier and I"

A Faithful Steed is just that: a loyal and dependable companion who carries you. This Template can apply to any creature which will carry a rider. Obviously, this usually means that humanoids, goblinoids, and outsiders are right out. Still, any reasonable mount will do, which depends on the nature of the rider as much as the Steed.

To create a Faithful Steed simply apply the following modifications:

Superior Breeding. A Faithful Steed gains a +2 bonus to its Initiative, Natural Armor Rating, and Saves.

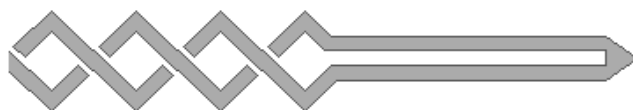
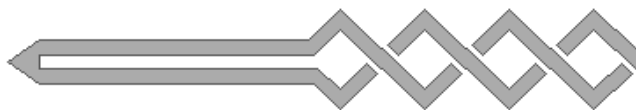
Furious Defense. A Faithful Steed becomes berserk when its master is gravely wounded. When the master is dealt a lethal blow or falls below 10% of his or her hit points, the steed gains +4 Strength, +4 Con, +2 on Will saves and -2 on it's AC for the next 10 combat rounds.

Calling. A Faithful Steed knows intrinsically when it will be needed. Not only can a character direct it to a specific place with any kind of communication, but the steed automatically comes to a location if the character will need it there soon. This doesn't help the Steed to move through terrain is cannot normally bypass, but may allow it to meet up with the master after being separated.

Challenge Rating. If it matters, this template carries a +1 ECL adjustment since it's worth 45 CP [Improved Initiative +2 (3), Defense +2 (12), Resistance +6 total (18), Berserker (6), and an Occult Sense (6)].

Players who design their own companions are, of course, free to modify this template as usual.





Nature Spirit

Varska silently crept by the forests' river bank, closely following his prey. Licking his ragged lips, anticipating the kill, he knew only that the elf's flesh would feed his carnivorous kin. Unfortunately for the troll, his preoccupation with blood meant he did not notice the man-like form rise from the swelling waters.

The encounter was quick and decisive, and the Troll never returned to haunt the forests beyond the great river, for it was well protected from evils like him. Though his arm returned in time, the growing was both slow and painful, a lesson well paid for.

Nature spirits are just that – spirits of natural elements and forces. Just as people have spirits, so do streams, trees, and forests. An ordinary spirit can be quite formidable. A powerful one is nigh-invulnerable. They are also relatively immobile. They can *never* leave the confines of their domain and have few ways of affecting the world outside of it.

To create a Nature Spirit simply apply the following template:

Base: Outsiders, humanoids, goblinoids, animals, or any plant creature with 13 or more hit dice.

Type: Change to Native Outsider.

Special Features

Immortality. A spirit is tied to a natural feature, such as a stream, a herd of animals, or a grove of trees. They cannot be killed permanently without destroying their natural feature entirely. This goes right down to slaughtering cubs and tearing out seeds. Damming streams will only annoy the spirit in charge. If “killed” without such measures the spirit returns in 28 days.

Discorporation. A Nature Spirit does not need to have a physical body. It can transform itself into a free-floating ethereal entity. In this state it can see, hear, and perceive all along its stream, pack, grove, as if it were looking out through them from all angles.

Mind. A creature who takes this template can project *Clairvoyance* to any section of its stream, a grove it controls, or whatever appropriate section it possesses. Any animal or plant creature may use this on any animal or plant under its care instead. It may use this power even while using a physical body.

Static. A Nature Spirit cannot leave its personal herd, pack, lake, river, wood, etc. They have no way around this, although they can go on astral journeys or similar adventures with the proper magical aid.

Special Abilities

Elemental Control. Nature Spirits can use *Telekinesis* at will on whatever their domain is (water, plants, soil) anywhere within their domain at any time. In the case of animal, humanoid, or goblinoid Nature Spirits, they may use their *Telekinesis* as if it originated from any creature of their type within their domain.

Variable Powers

Incorporeal. All elementals, humanoids, or goblinoids, including earth elementals, who receive this template gain the incorporeal type; they simply allow attacks to slide right through.

Privilege: A Nature Spirit may subtract 6 CP from a target once per day per target. The spirit chooses where the CP are lost from, although they do not gain any information about the target's abilities except from their own observations. This lasts for 24 hours and has a range of 30 feet. There is no save. They may similarly add 6 CP to a character once per day per target for 24 hours, although the ability bestowed must have something to do with the feature the spirit controls. A deer spirit might thus grant increased celerity or enhance Survival skill checks.

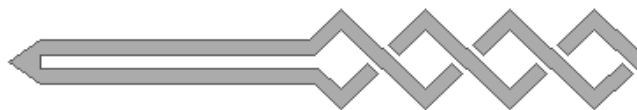
Summoning. Plants and animals who have this template gain *Summon Nature's Ally* (at a Spell Level equal to half their Charisma score) 3/day.

Level Adjustment: +6

Nature Spirits in the Game

As you might expect, elementals who take this template normally look after natural features, plants after flora, and animals after living creatures. Most often, these are separate from actual elementals, plants, or animals. While these can become Nature Spirits in some settings, as a default Nature Spirits do not actually come from such beings. Humanoids and goblinoids with this template normally follow the lead of the elementals or look after mortal beings' homes and structures. They tend to be the dead ancestors of the living.

Nature spirits are not always good, at least not in the way people think of good and evil. They are protectors of things far larger or more intricate than mortal empires, and which survive far longer. Nature spirits can even war for control of packs and herds, forests, or rivers. They tend to have a feudalistic outlook. The more powerful ones make vassals of the weak. The greatest may go on to become Realm Spirits.



Realm Spirit

"I am Gormnadas, Master of the Earthen Bones, Render of Rifts, Ruler of the Continental Divide! You had better have a very good reason as to why you think I should stop my battle with the Subcontinent because of your pitiful little civilization."

Realm spirits are the great form of Nature Spirits. They control whole regions or domains, such as a forest, mountain range, mighty river, a hurricane, an entire species of animals, or the sea. Each looks after many small Nature Spirits. They can be fierce if provoked, but doing so is rather difficult. The fact is that such beings find humanity (along with elves, dwarves, and so on) too small to notice. They might notice giants or dragons, but probably wouldn't care; they think on the scale of eons and continents. In most games, all of human and even elven civilization is simply not worth noting.

Realm spirits are immortal. Unless an adventure actively destroys the entire realm from the roots up, the Realm Spirit will remain. And while wizards are powerful, few of them have the power to destroy a mountain range, permanently stop a mighty river, or obliterate a whole species.

Such entities often have great wisdom and knowledge, and may well be willing to extend a bit of aid to those who require assistance. More than anything else, they merely enjoy appreciation. As Realm Spirits, they have no need of magical power, wealth, or servants. The only thing one could possibly need is help on some mighty project to improve the land, sea, sky, or ecology.

Like Nature Spirits, Realm Spirits are immobile, although their greater scope means they have less to worry about outside their domains.

The Realm Spirit Template

Base: Outsiders, humanoids and goblinoids, Animals, or any Plant creature with 13 or more hit dice.

Type: Change to Native Outsider.

Special Attacks

Improved Elemental Control. Realm spirits may manipulate animals, plantlife, and natural features with ease on a whim within their domain. If used as an attack, they can usually deal anywhere from 4d6-10d6 bludgeoning damage (or other appropriate type) and they do not miss unless they're just giving warnings.

Special Qualities

Immortality. These spirits have the same immortality as Nature Spirits: if you destroy every last scrap of their realm, they die. However, this amounts to attempting to

kill mountains, eradicate every last tree in a forest, or exterminate whole species.

Resurrection. A Realm spirit can *Truely Resurrect* a truly deceased Nature spirit at will. It must, however, first locate a spare stream, herd, grove to settle them on, as appropriate to the spirit.

Typeless. Realms spirits have no type. They are immune to all spells which target creatures by type or which have different effects depending on the type of creature affected.

Whole Mind. Realm spirits are immune to mind-affecting spells and effects. Trying to use such magic on a Realm spirit causes the caster or user to become stunned for 24 hours, as the vast mental flow of the Realm Spirit overwhelms him or her. Additionally, Realm Spirits are always aware of everything that happens in their realms.

Master's Privilege: A Realm Spirit may subtract 18 CP from a target (dividing the 18 CP any way it pleases) once per month per target. The spirit chooses where the CP are lost from, although they do not gain any information about the target's abilities except from their own observations. This lasts for one month and affects any target within the spirit's realm. There is no save. They may similarly add 18 CP, although the abilities bestowed must have something to do with the spirit's realm. A mountain spirit might grant damage reduction, enhanced strength, or superb climbing abilities.

Static. A Realm Spirit cannot leave its domain. They have no way around this, although they can go on astral journeys or similar adventures with the proper magical aid.

Level Adjustment: +9

Realm Spirits in the Game

Realm spirits are not generally meant as characters. Only the most powerful of mortals or most important changes in the world can attract their attention. They can and will carry on a conversation normally, but they rarely find anything or anyone interesting enough to try.

Finally, a Realm Spirit cannot lie (at least, not intentionally). Their connection to the vast world has rendered them incapable of using mere deception on a scale intelligible to mortals. Realm spirits can deceive, but only on a scale so large it means nothing to humans. A Realm Spirit deceives about where a volcanic eruption or continental shift may occur, and does so only with other Realm Spirits, gods, or other greater beings. It also does so implicitly, by "body language," not with mere words.



Epic Monsters

No matter what you do with basic creature statistics, someone's going to get themselves enough power to handily smash it. If you want a truly Epic monster, it should come from outside the normal world, obey alien laws of nature, be unique, and be nigh-indestructible by simple violence. Defeating it should be a matter of wits and quests, not a numbers festival.

Therefore, these monsters can't die from ordinary attacks. All those super-death spells and mega-vorpal blades do virtually nothing to these things. The key to victory lies in discovering their weaknesses and finding a way to use that to defeat them. This makes the monsters listed here an appropriate challenge for any party with strong magical resources. It can even become another type of quest, with the party searching out a specific artifact or the materials to make such an item.

GM's can follow your player's leads on this. If they analyze its weaknesses and think up a device or technique that you think could work, let them give it a shot. If they go asking greater powers for help, let them run an adventure that way. If they seek out magical items to do the trick, run the adventure on that basis. Let *them* come up with the solution.

Each creature here isn't meant to be the entire adventure in and of itself. The real adventure may involve encountering or avoiding the monster several times, then searching for information on it. The characters can finally develop a theory of its weaknesses, develop the weapons needed, and ultimately kill it.



The Beast

Characters can become very frustrated when fighting the Beast. A vast animalistic monster, with a hide far thicker than a dragon's and enough spines to impale a mountain, the Beast consumes whole regions in a destructive fury beyond any other being's. The Beast is composed of only three things: an awesome amount of raw life energy imbued with utter hatred, the ability to feed off positive or negative energy, and a shell of meat covering the energy within. It automatically strikes any creature below the size of a large mountain that it chooses to hit and deals 10d6 damage per strike, striking three times per round and bypassing damage reduction. In essence, it attacks the target's life force and is big enough to attack whole towns with a single stomp.

It has AC 60 and near-unlimited hit points. It has no vital points and does not need its head to survive. Unless utterly incinerated (and even then the dust may still be dangerous) any blood or bits of tissue it sheds spring to life as vicious monsters, attack any creature or plant nearby, and begin feeding vitality back into the Beast, regenerating it at an exponential rate. Essentially, it regenerates all damage within moments, providing the creatures (plants and animals) near it have sufficient hit points in total to heal it. The secondary monsters vanish after an hour or so and don't spawn others. A large-scale area attack (like a *Fireball*, but covering a whole mountain-sized area) should handily destroy the minor creatures.

How to win. The Beast can theoretically be killed. Dealing enough damage fast enough to kill it is the trick. It can't regenerate if there are no living creatures or plants nearby, so casting it into a void or barren plane works. If the characters can halt it along a planetary ley line or other mystically important site, they might be able to trap it under the earth. That might call for some amazing grapple checks (with DC's measured in the 100-150 range) if they actually plan to physically haul it down or for some awesome magical ritual otherwise.

The Rad-Fiend

This terrifying monster has a fascinating power: it exudes radiation which breaks down organic matter into more radiation. It has no body; the creature simply is nothing more than radiation with a simple program and magical sensors system attached. It is considered a construct, cannot be mind-controlled, and has specific invulnerability to all physical, energy, and magical damage, ability drain, disintegrate and all other instant-death effects, albeit only a few hundred hits. Damaging negative energy turning can cause injury, but it has Resistance (not Turn Resistance) 20 to that. Positive energy turning heals 12 hit points. In order to turn it, a creature must be inside the Rad-Fiend's radius.



The creature is a 5-mile sphere of radiation. Any creature caught within it takes 5 damage per round. Any creature that leaves the radius after taking damage takes 1 point per round until they die or something stops the progressive disintegration. A limited wish or special-use effect can fix this. This is considered "radiation" type damage and bypasses all damage reduction and magical resistances. Only special-purpose radiation resistance works. The creature can sense life and attacks it, but probably won't even notice the characters – Rad-Fiends attack cities and forests, not individuals.

How to win. Try using the weakness to damaging negative energy. Turning causes it no damage unless the cleric is very skilled, but if he or she can gain a power boost, it might be possible due to the really low hit points. Alternative methods might include using negative energy from another plane where it is an abundant resource, combining the efforts of hundreds of negative-energy users, or gathering such power from a large stock of potent undead.

The Madscimind

The Madscimind has no physical presence, existing as a pure unconscious impulse. It lives (if one can call it that) solely to put ideas for horrible and awesomely destructive weapons into the minds of individuals insane enough to use them and talented enough to make them, thus neatly explaining where a great many artifacts came from. The Madscimind works on the level of dreams and nightmares, lying in a twisted labyrinth of arithmetic and magic.

How to win. In order to attack it, the characters have to realize it exists at all. One way to suggest this might be to suddenly have a rash of madmen get their grubby hands on some strange, insane weaponry. Aside from running several fearsome fights this way, the players (and hopefully characters) will wonder what's going on.

Any investigations into the minds, magical auras, or homes of the madmen could reveal a connection to the realm of dreams. Actually getting to the monster requires them to keep going into the darkest nightmares. They'll have to face their own fears and other's terrors, finally entering a horrific realm of utter madness.

The creature, once reached, dies easily – it's nothing more than an unconscious urge combined with vast technical knowledge and has very little real power. Unfortunately, to finish the job, they'll have to locate every mind it has touched and clean them of the Madscimind's influence. Otherwise, it will be reborn. This could be quite troublesome if it's given any of the player characters ideas. Still, thoroughly killing it in the dream world will keep it quiet for centuries or eons – although eventually some naturally-occurring mad genius might respawn it.

A Long Long Time Ago..... In A Distant Campaign....

The Orb

The greatest project and ultimate weapon of some mighty evil race, the *Orb* is hundred-miles wide golem-construct powered by the collected life forces of scores of *Gibbering Orbs* or thousands of their lesser relatives. Piloted and enhanced by a group of evil entities using the *Rider* ability sequence to augment the *Orb*'s already-vast powers and defenses, the *Orb* is a base from which to subjugate entire galaxies. Its antimagic ray can shatter the mightiest city-based or even planetary wards, its charm-beam can ensorcell a continent with a single blast, and its onboard legions suffice to seize the wealth of an entire world in short order before moving on the rest of the galaxy. Now that it's operational, the *Orb* is the greatest power - and threat - which the galaxy has ever seen. Before it the gods themselves are mere outmoded superstitions and their flame shall vanish from the universe!

How to win. A heroic group could sneak aboard and try to deactivate the antimagic ray, allowing a massed attack from the planetary surface. Since no design is perfect, perhaps they could somehow steal the plans and find some vital or vulnerable spot. Given the immense scale of the *Orb*'s abilities, the energies bound up in its power core must be equally great; a courageous and fast-moving group might be able to strike at that core (and hopefully outrun the ensuing explosion). Of course, the *Orb* will have many *Eye-Fighters* at the ready to counter this.

The Page Demon

The Page Demon is a vicious, cruel monster. It's also nearly invincible. Able to transfer itself to any book, page, magazine, newspaper, catalogue, or any paper-like substance with a written word on it, and survive the destruction of any such media, ordinary weapons won't do. If it targets a character, it will attempt to draw them





into its maw (Ref save DC 24 to resist), imprinting them on the page. A *Resurrection* spell, *Wish*, or *Miracle* can restore the deceased. Unlike most of these monsters, the Page Demon isn't very dangerous to powerful player characters, but it can anger them or hinder them (by screwing with scrolls, books, and so on), and so interest the party in killing it.

How to win. The Page Demon exists on a level mortal beings can't comprehend. Killing it would involve erasing that dimension in one of two ways: destroying all written words and/or paper on the plane (guaranteed not to be popular) or entering its realm and hunting it out. Since it doesn't have a 3-dimensional form, would be visitors must transform themselves into 2-dimensional beings or cast a spell to temporarily translate information from that two-dimensional world for them. Either is likely to involve considerable magical power. Once inside, it has the stats of a Hunefer or any other big, scary creature you want to use.

The Worm-Thing

Similar to a *Worm that Walks*, only much, much worse, the Worm-Thing attempts to become the last word in survival. Its body is made of a roiling mass of Worms or it may take any other shape (given that these

are high-level spellcasters by definition, they can easily transform). As it happens, it can also take over a vast number of creatures by attacking them with its worms. The worms attack and take over the host; the Worm-Thing can control them (there's a reason we don't bother with a save – see below). Even better, if even a single worm survives, so does the Worm-Thing. They usually also lock up several spare bodies in protected pocket dimension stasis cocoons, several in other planes, and have a few stashed around for general use.

How to win. As it happens, killing the Worm-Thing is almost impossible. It can be done by getting every last worm in every dimension and safe house. That isn't likely. Fortunately, the Worm-Thing has one weakness: it's too reasonable. While inhuman, it has no reason to hurt anyone. Becoming a weird monster has the unusual effect of making them simply apathetic. Worm-Things don't care about ruling or leading hordes of darkness. They might become mercenaries for other powerful beings because it pays well and there are some things more easily bought than found or taken. They don't usually bother to take over sentient beings' forms. Why would they, when taking over a large, dumb beast and transforming it into a more useful shape is so much easier and safer? They don't worry about food, shelter, or clothing. They're just nigh-impossible to kill.

